

CAMBRIDGE HARKENER

CELEBRATING THE HERITAGE OF CAMBRIDGE, VERMONT

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1895-1977

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Installment II

On September 4, 1918 Don would write a poem about the events of August 28, 1919 (excerpts below:

To my Pal - Bobbie Burns



*It was 9 in the morning
 When we took our positions in line
 And a sip from a French Canteen
 Made us feel fine.*

*We stood side by side when the order came
 To go 'over the top'
 And advance down the lane.*

*Old Bob was up front and dong his "bit"
 When a shrapnel shell
 Made a direct hit*

*That night when I crawled in for a little sleep
 I prayed to God Bob's soul to keep
 I miss you Bob
 Far more than I can say*

Don's diary entries say the following: "Sept 4,...Looked for Bob"; Sept 5, "...No news from Bob"; Sept 7, "...got Bob's Pack"; Sept 19, "...No news of Bob"; Sept 25, "...mail letter Bob Burns".

In a December 3, 1918 letter to his sister Lizzie, Uncle Rob wrote "the only thing I lost that I felt bad over was the sweater that Carlie knit and sent me just before I left Camp for over here. That was in my pack and we left those before we went in to the front line..." Don recovered that sweater when he found Uncle Rob's pack, and we have it now among Uncle Rob's WWI items.

Uncle Rob's father received two telegrams from Washington DC: one, dated Dec 13, 1918 said, "Deeply regret to inform you that it is officially reported that Private Robert M. Burns Infantry died October Ninth from wounds received in action." Another, dated Dec 8, 1918,, said "Happy to advise that Private Robert M. Burns Infantry previously reported died October Ninth from wounds received in action was in error. He was wounded in action

Early History of Cambridge

by Ida Morgan Anderson

Beginning in 1935, Ida Morgan Anderson began serializing a column on the History of Cambridge in the *Cambridge Town Crier*. Many of our readers may remember the series of 27 Installments. The Harkener continues publishing the installments for a new audience on the assumption that the copyright (if it ever existed) has long since expired. We hope you will enjoy these "blasts from the past."

Installment Twenty-one

In the spring and summer of 1872 the pigeons were very numerous and many fields of grain were damaged by them. A party of seven set out to secure some of the squabs for eating. Among this party were Joseph Morgan, Nathaniel Griffin, Thomas Edwards, Leonard Holmes & Charles Melendy. Travelling up through the forest in the notch they finally came upon the body of the nests in a stand of old growth timber.

"There was just a pair of young birds in each nest, never more, and seldom one alone in the nest! Immediately we set to work to kill and dress some of them, and after sprinkling with salt, roasted them over a fire and ate them with the victuals we had brought. I have often affirmed that in all my life I never partook of such an appetizing meal. During this time we did not see so much as a single old bird nor did we till just before the sun went down behind the hills. Then they came not by hundreds, not by thousands, but in countless hosts that could not be numbered, until the very woods around us were black with them. The sound of their wings was like a mighty rush of wind, and their screams when they found their retreat impeded, were so loud that we had to shout at the top of our voice in order to hear each other.

Such vast flocks alighted on the limbs that they frequently broke and we had to guard against being injured by their fall. So frightened were the birds by our presence, the sound of our guns and the light of the fires, that they would frequently light so near that we could touch them with our hands. We tented on the resting grounds that night and just as the day was breaking they commenced their departure to the westward, the direction from which they came the night before, and before sunrise none of them remained.

At sunrise we started homeward with our sacks well filled with young squabs which we had

killed and dressed during the night. They were very good when cooked at home, but none of us relished them as we did those we broiled on the mountain tops which overlook the village of Johnson from its western side."

That same year of 1842 was remarkable for a June snowstorm and the unseasonably hot weather all through May and part of June, which was more like July weather. This same minister writing of it said:

"On the 9th of June, I helped to hoe a piece of corn which was nearly large enough to 'half hill' or hoe the second time. People in those days never thought of raising a crop of corn without three hoeings, and the work must be well done at that. That afternoon the sky became cloudy and just before dark, hazy, ominous looking clouds began to rise in the western horizon. On the morning of the

10th the clouds had disappeared, the sky was once more clear and the sun shone out in all its radiant beauty, but its ray fell not upon the blooming trees and green fields as they did the day before, but upon a body of snow which had fallen the night previous to a depth of 13 to 14 inches. Robins and other small birds were com-

pletely snow blind and the boys caught numbers of them as they fluttered and wallowed to and fro through the snow which covered trees, fences, buildings and every other object on which a bird would naturally alight. Of course the snow made but a short stop, for when the sun came out it soon disappeared.

On the morning of the 10th Joseph Gallup, Sen., started for Burlington on business, driving a span of horses hitched to a double sleigh so that he might have it to say that he had driven from his mountain home in Cambridge to Burlington on runners in the month of June. Being asked by his neighbours as he was returning home that night how the sleighing was toward the lake, he replied that it was getting pretty thin in some places and he was thinking of putting up his sleigh when he got home and using his wagon for the season."



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degree undetermined about Sept. second." The dates on the telegrams and the date confusion in the telegrams, do not align with Uncle Rob's MIA result after the August 28 action.

We do not know how news of WWI casualties traveled around Vermont in 1918; however, the package of letters that the Burns family saved contains ten letters expressing the writer's sympathy for the death of Robert Burns. These letters were written between November 10 and December 26, 1918 so some of these letters predate the telegrams noted above. There must have been additional communication channels at that time.

On September 7, 1918 Uncle Rob would write to Dear Bud (Don): "Shrapnel went through my right leg below the knee and did not hit the bone. The French picked me up and I was in a French hospital for four days and am now in Orleans in American Base Hospital 202 so am getting along all OK now."

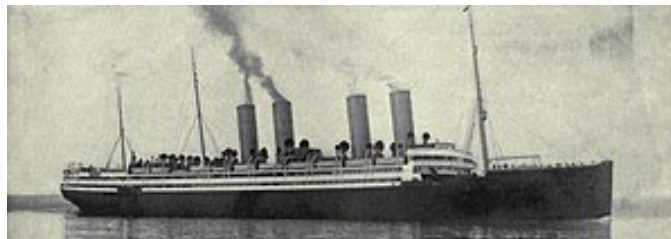
In another letter to Don written in November 24, 1918 Uncle Rob wrote: "I tell you I was mighty pleased to see them coming as the walking was rather hard on me."

Confusion about Uncle Rob's life or death, as communicated to his family, continued into the new year. On January 3, 1919 Uncle Rob would write "Dear Folks...I would have felt bad had I been in your place. Don't believe that I am dead until you hear it straight from me that I am!"

In a letter to Don dated January 24, 1919 Uncle Rob explained this further: "...I was especially sorry to hear of the death of Sgt. Robert Burns as I think he was an extra considerate Sgt...His name you know is the same as mine... Washington sent word to my folks in Cambridge, VT that I was dead instead of sending it to Watertown, NY... there was about two weeks that they believed me finished."

In a letter to his Sister, dated March 17, 1919 Uncle Rob said: "...in the four days on the front line Co. H had a few over 200 men when they went in there and had 65 when they counted up after being relieved.." In a letter to his parents dated March 11, 1919, Uncle Rob wrote: "I left Orleans (Bas 202) on Feb 17 and went to Base 88 in Savanay, France and stayed there a few days over a week then was sent to Brest to Evacuation Hospital 20 and stayed there until March 3."

Uncle Rob sailed for USA March 3, 1919 on the ship Mt. Vermont, he and 8000 other soldiers arrived in NYC Harbor on March 10, 1919. Uncle Rob strolled up 5th Avenue and witnessed the St. Patrick's Day Parade on March 17, 1919. He received an Honorable Discharge from the US Army at Camp Devens, MA on March 28, 1919.



To Be Continued....



In the March 2023 issue of the Harkener we printed this mystery picture.

Jen Bartlau has identified the location:

“It’s the 1st house on the right on Pumpkin Harbor Road (heading to Fletcher) after the turn to North Cambridge Rd.

“On the left, after the Machia house, a branch of the Lamoille came up to the road & still floods today. That’s what the people are rowing on.”

Upcoming Programs

June 12

History of Cambridge High School Sports
Spencer Noble

July 10

Green Mountain Byway
Ron Carter

August 14

Alcohol in the Green Mountain State
Rebecca Rupp

September 11

Reading Maps (of Cambridge)
Liam Kearney

October 9

Alden Memorial Gallery 40th Anniversary
a Conversation with Jane Shaw

November 13

CHS Annual Meeting

All meetings are held at the Warner Lodge
49 School Street, Jeffersonville
7:00 pm

There is no fee but there will be refreshments
All are welcome.

**The Warner Lodge will be open on the Fourth of July from 10 am to 2 pm. We will have a
new slide show and the Masonic Lodge Room will be open.**
Stop in and say hello!

Membership Application/Renewal

Please complete this form and mail to: Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464-0016
or email to: rgtle@stoweaccess.com

☐ New

☐ Renewal

Name _____

Address _____
Number Street Town State Zip

Phone _____ E-Mail _____

Membership Category

☐ Individual \$20.00

☐ Family \$30.00

☐ Business \$30.00

Please consider becoming a:

☐ Patron \$500.00

☐ Benefactor \$1,000.00+

☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐

If you have suggestions about program topics or have some great ideas for fundraisers,
please let us know by listing your ideas below.

Cambridge Historical Society
PO Box 16
Jeffersonville, VT 05464



Attendance at our meetings so far this year have been impressive. We've heard about Vikings and Chicanes so far and this month we revisit Cambridge High School to learn about the sports program. We hope you can join us for this or one of our other programs this year.

This Newsletter in one of the perks of membership, so to continue receiving The Harkener renew your membership, and THANK YOU.